

needed to set aside for weekly living costs, including paying down her debt, she was left to run her own show.

That was mistake number one. In about six months, Emily proved incapable of sticking to her budget. Her credit card debts remained on the edge and, even worse, she was using cash from her credit card for everyday living. In the no-noes of credit card use, that's the biggest. Credit card cash is not king; it's a daily interest-rate nightmare. She was going backwards.

We hosted another round of Emily wailing on the floor in the foetal position.

Drastic action needed to be taken. Simply, I decided that despite her age and the fact she'd flown the family coop a dozen years earlier, she couldn't be trusted. Telling her that wasn't easy, but it was as necessary as it would be in any 'intervention'.

We devised a plan for her mother and me to take complete control of Emily's money, paying her bills and building her savings. She would receive a fortnightly 'allowance' – the so-called pocket money – from which she would pay for her food, transport and entertainment. Any requests for money beyond that would require an inquisition that would make the Spanish look soft.

This was tough love, especially for a young woman in her work and social prime. Spending \$200 on cocktails on a Friday night with her friends was out of the question, unless she could be so frugal during the week as to leave herself with some extra pocket money.

To really make the sacrifice work, she had to have a goal beyond just saving to survive. The savings needed to be for a purpose, like a footballer sacrificing to win a grand final. For Emily, buying her own home was the Holy Grail, with the first target a balance of \$50,000 that would probably take at least three years to accumulate. The real aim is to save about \$80,000 to \$100,000 – a suitable and sizeable deposit.

Like all addicts, Emily has fallen off the wagon at times. However, with her mother and me in control of her finances, she can only spend what she has in her sweaty paw, and under our rules that was never going to be any more than \$350 a week – and if she spent it, there was no more.